UNIQUE MARKETING ISSUES · ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Found, chosen, *booked.*

How an entrepreneurial firm finds its customers, and how AI finds it.

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MODULE
MKT101 / ENT101
Unique Marketing Issues

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CASE STUDY · NO. 01

RUKA
MALDIVES

THE CASE

Ruka Maldives, Dhiffushi, North Malé Atoll. A real twelve-room boutique guesthouse with a cosy, boho, island-villa feel, used with the owner's permission.

THE ENTREPRENEURIAL DILEMMA

The Ruka Maldives *dilemma*

PROPERTY	Ruka Maldives
LOCATION	Dhiffushi, North Malé Atoll
SIZE	12 rooms · opened 2025
STYLE	Cosy boho guesthouse · courtyard dining
WEBSITE	*None of its own*

A traveller asks an AI for "a cosy, aesthetic, budget-friendly guesthouse near the beach". How does a new venture get chosen when the AI is the gatekeeper?

THE AI SEARCH PROBLEM



Hundreds of rooms. The AI shows *three.*

Will Ruka make the list?

"Fewer opportunities to appear, but more impact if you do." Morand & Schegg, 2026

abdullamuizfuad.github.io/GEO-Visibility-/demo

YOUR TURN

Be the *traveller.*

01 Scan the code with your camera

02 Pick a traveller: Couple, Solo, Family or Dive

03 Tap Search and read the AI's answer

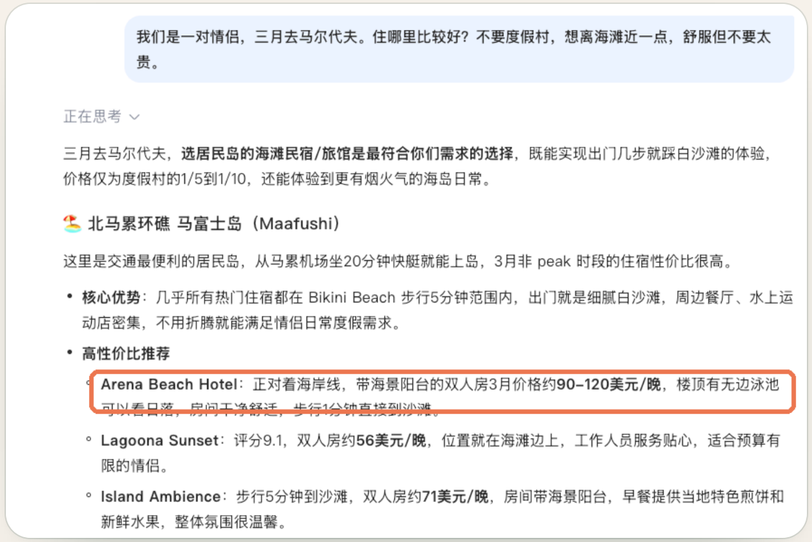
04 Watch the screen

Pause at the question: "Why do you think the AI left Ruka out?"

Same questions, *real* AI engines

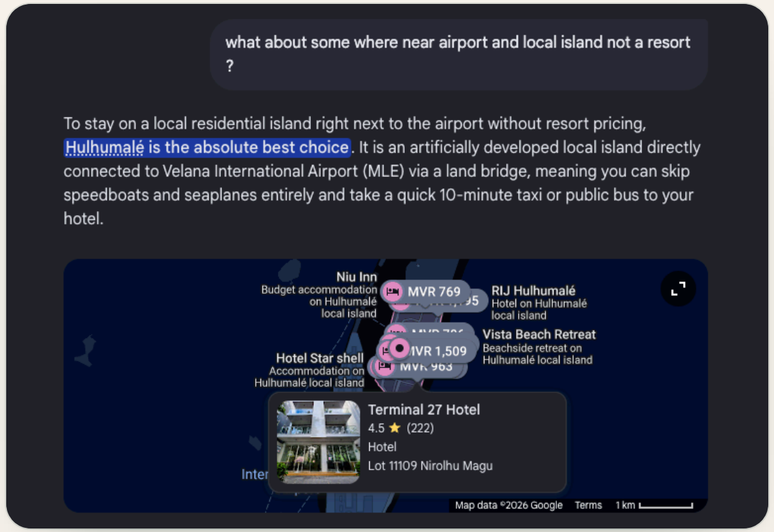
Baidu

In Chinese: “We’re a couple… not a resort, near the beach.”



Google AI Mode

“Near the airport, a local island, not a resort.”



0

times Ruka Maldives was named

Arena Beach Hotel: Baidu’s first pick for couples, Gemini’s for families

Dhiffushi recommended, with **Athiri Residence**, not Ruka

Google’s picks all carry a **rating, map pin & website**

Four questions every *venture* must answer

Answer each for Ruka, and place it on the Business Model Canvas.

01

Who?

Segment the market, choose a target and state one clear position.

Canvas: Customer Segments + Value Proposition

02

Why us?

Build a brand that earns trust despite the liability of newness.

Canvas: Value Proposition

03

What & how?

Set product, price, place and promotion so guests and AI can check them.

Canvas: Channels + Revenue Streams

04

Closing the deal

Use the seven-step sales process to turn an enquiry into a booking.

Canvas: Customer Relationships

Barringer & Ireland, “Unique Marketing Issues”: written for new ventures facing the liability of newness

OBJECTIVE ONE

Segment, target, *position.*

Three steps entrepreneurial firms use to find the customers they can serve best.

01	**Segment** WHO COULD STAY?	Couples & honeymooners · Solo travellers · Small families · Divers Divide a broad market into groups that share needs and characteristics.
02	**Target** WHO DO WE SERVE BEST?	*Couples, solo travellers, small families*, on a budget, near Malé Choose the segments where the firm has a real advantage; divers are left out.
03	**Position** WHY US, NOT THEM?	*"A cosy boutique home-away-from-home on Dhiffushi: twelve boho rooms, courtyard dining, steps from the beach."*

ONE BRAND, THREE PROOF POINTS

Couples: intimate boho style and courtyard dining. **Solo:** privacy and serviced living on a budget. **Families:** villa-style living, indoor and courtyard dining. An AI repeats a position only if it can verify it.

OBJECTIVE TWO

A brand is a promise people, *and AI,* recognise

> A brand is the set of attributes, positive or negative, that people associate with a company.
>
> *Barringer & Ireland, Entrepreneurship*

- **Liability of newness:** with no track record, the brand must create trust
- **Price premium:** a trusted name earns more and repeat stays
- **Brand equity:** consistent signals add up to value and loyalty
- **Recognition:** people and AI recommend only what they can identify

A FRACTURED FOOTPRINT

TEACHING SCENARIO

BOOKING SITE	**Ruka Inn** *Reviews split across names*	+960 7XX **1234**
MAP LISTING	**Ruka Guest House** *Treated as a separate business*	**no phone**
SOCIAL MEDIA	**Ruka Maldives** *Customers confused; booking signals lost*	+960 9XX **5678**

A UNIFIED FOOTPRINT

Ruka Maldives

Same name, address and phone everywhere, so every review and booking signal builds one brand's equity, and one entity an AI can recognise.

Name · Address · Phone, identical everywhere

The marketing mix in the *generative* era

01

Product

Sell the core benefit with facts a guest can check.

GEO twist: AI repeats verifiable facts, not adjectives.

12-room boho guesthouse · courtyard dining · serviced living · breakfast included

02

Price

Price on **cost** (costs plus margin) or on **value** (what guests think it is worth).

GEO twist: publish clear price ranges and terms so AI can qualify guests.

03

Place

Sell **direct** or through **intermediaries** such as OTAs, which take commission.

GEO twist: AI assistants are the newest intermediary.

04

Promotion

Advertising, public relations, social media and reviews build awareness.

GEO twist: structure content so AI can extract and summarise it.

OBJECTIVE FOUR

AI opens doors; *you* close the sale

1 **Prospect for leads**
Travellers looking for a Dhiffushi stay
AI-ASSISTED

2 **Initial contact**
The first answer to an enquiry
AI-ASSISTED

3 **Qualify the lead**
Budget, dates and fit confirmed
AI-ASSISTED

4 **Sales presentation**
Rooms, courtyard and breakfast presented
AI-ASSISTED

5 **Meet objections**
“Can you arrange a courtyard dinner for our anniversary?”
HUMAN TOUCH

6 **Close the sale**
Deposit and confirmation
HUMAN TOUCH

7 **Follow-up & retention**
Reviews and repeat stays
HUMAN TOUCH

Steps one to four: the AI finds, filters and presents for you. A guest who clicks through arrives pre-qualified.

Steps five to seven: objections, the close and the relationship still belong to the guesthouse.

• DISCUSSION

If AI handles steps one to four, how does the guesthouse manager's role change?

Turn to your neighbour. Which touchpoints should stay human, and which can be automated?

01

Administrative responder → experience architect: less time on repeat enquiries, more on designing the stay.

02

Passive marketer → data curator: keeping Ruka's digital facts accurate everywhere.

Keep the demo open

YOUR TURN

Now, make Ruka *visible.*

BRAND	One name, address and phone everywhere
PRODUCT	Facts: boho style, courtyard dining, serviced living
PRICE	A clear price range and terms, published
PLACE	Bookable direct and on OTAs, details identical

Now tap Search again.

TRAVELLER: A COUPLE / HONEYMOON

1. *Ruka Maldives*
2. Stone Hotels Dhiffushi
3. Arena Beach Hotel

- **Solo & family:** Ruka moves up the list
- **Dive:** still not a fit; Reveries wins

Picked the dive couple? Reveries still wins. Positioning means choosing.

Measuring learning: from memory to *application*

FORMATIVE

Understand

Exit ticket

“In one sentence, state Ruka’s position for honeymooners and how an AI could verify it.”

Two minutes, end of class · instant feedback

REMEMBERING

SUMMATIVE

Apply

Exam question

“Explain the seven-step sales process for a Maldivian guesthouse: which steps can AI assist, and where do humans remain critical?”

Short answer · 10 marks

GROUP PROJECT · 30%

Analyse · Create

AI visibility audit

In groups, audit a real Maldivian guesthouse on ChatGPT, Gemini, Google and Booking.com, then build its Business Model Canvas and pitch a revised STP and 4Ps.

Rubric: audit 30 · canvas & STP/4Ps 50 · pitch 20

APPLYING IN THE FIELD →

Found. Chosen. *Booked.*

01 **STP:** one core brand, with proof points each segment can verify

02 **Brand:** consistency beats the liability of newness

03 **4Ps:** verifiable facts, for people and for AI

04 **Sales:** AI for discovery; humans close and retain

MY TEACHING PHILOSOPHY

Students learn best by applying theory to real, local challenges. I ground Barringer & Ireland and the Business Model Canvas in live disruptions, like AI search.

Abdulla Muiz Fuad

Questions?

References & *sources*

Aggarwal, P., et al. (2024). GEO: Generative engine optimization. *Proceedings of the 30th ACM SIGKDD Conference on Knowledge Discovery and Data Mining*.

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Osterwalder, A., & Pigneur, Y. (2010). *Business model generation*. Wiley.

Ruka Maldives is used with the owner's permission. Ruka, Stone Hotels Dhiffushi, Reveries Diving Village and Arena Beach Hotel are described only with publicly listed facts; the "fractured footprint" is a teaching scenario. The phone demo is a scripted simulation, not a live AI. AI answers were captured on 4 November 2026.